

CROCODILES AND ALLIGATORS

Crocodylians are large, carnivorous, aquatic reptiles. Their armoured skin and powerful jaws make them formidable predators, yet they are sociable animals and caring parents.

All crocodylians – crocodiles, alligators, and gharials – have a similar body plan: an elongated snout armed with numerous, sharp, unspecialized teeth, a streamlined body, a long, muscular tail, and skin armoured with bony plates. The saltwater crocodile is the largest living reptile.

SWIMMING AND FEEDING

Crocodylians are found in tropical regions worldwide, inhabiting a variety of freshwater and marine habitats. The eyes, ears, and nostrils are on top of the head, which enables the animal to be almost completely submerged while hunting. The powerful tail is used for swimming and strong legs allow crocodylians to move readily on land with the body raised well above the ground.

Although generalist carnivores, feeding on fish, reptiles, birds, and mammals, crocodylians exhibit sophisticated feeding behaviours to locate and

ambush specific prey, such as migrating mammals and fish. Small prey is swallowed whole but large prey is first drowned before the crocodylian rolls over while grasping the carcass to twist off pieces of meat. Digestion is aided by stones in the stomach and highly acidic gastric secretions.

SOCIAL BEHAVIOUR AND BREEDING

Behaviourally, crocodylians have more in common with birds, their closest living relatives, than with other reptiles. Adults form loose groupings – particularly at good feeding sites – and use a wide range of vocalizations and body language to interact with each other.

In the breeding season, dominant males control territories and actively court females. Fertilization is internal and clutches of rigid-shelled eggs are laid in a nest constructed and guarded by the female. The sex of individuals is determined by the incubation temperature. Hatchlings call to stimulate the female to excavate the nest and carry them in her mouth to water. Mortality is high in young crocodylians but once they are longer than 1 m (3¼ ft), they have few natural enemies.

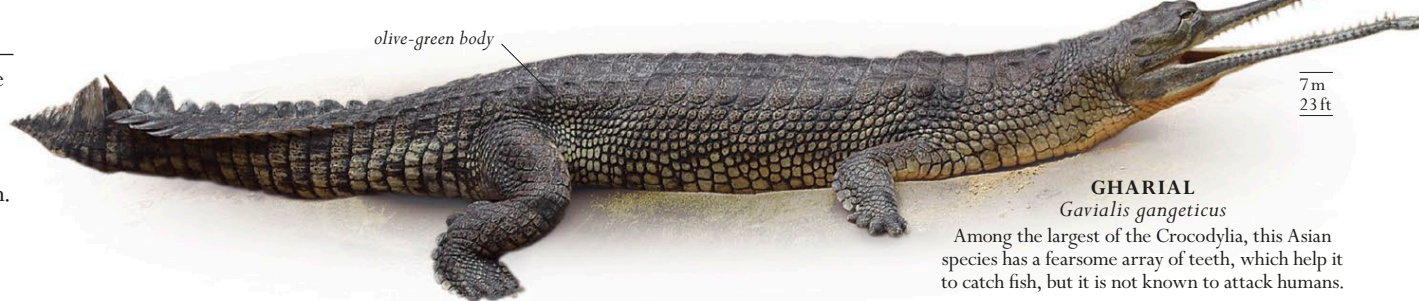
PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	REPTILIA
ORDER	CROCODYLIA
FAMILIES	3
SPECIES	25



Exploiting a fast-flowing stream, these Yacare caimans lie in wait with their mouth held open, waiting for a fish to come within reach.

GHARIALS

The endangered Gavialidae are restricted to India. The slender snout has rows of numerous sharp teeth that help to catch fish. Males develop a wart-like growth on the tip of the snout.



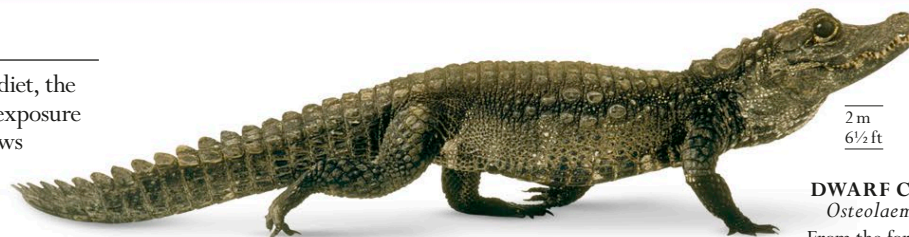
GHARIAL

Gavialis gangeticus

Among the largest of the Crocodylia, this Asian species has a fearsome array of teeth, which help it to catch fish, but it is not known to attack humans.

CROCODILES

Relatively unspecialized in lifestyle, habitat, and diet, the Crocodylidae are most easily recognized by the exposure of the fourth tooth of the lower jaw, when the jaws are closed. These tropical reptiles occupy many habitats around rivers and coasts.



DWARF CROCODILE

Osteolaemus tetraspis

From the forests of tropical Africa, this small crocodile has a heavy armour of scales on its neck and back. It is a nocturnal hunter of fish and frogs.



CUBAN CROCODILE

Crocodylus rhombifer

Endemic to Cuba, this medium-sized crocodile inhabits swamps, and hunts fish and small mammals. It lays its eggs in holes in the ground.



SIAMESE CROCODILE

Crocodylus siamensis

Restricted to S.E. Asia, this large crocodile is critically endangered in the wild. Found in freshwater marshes, it feeds on a variety of prey.



powerful tail propels crocodile through water